

The road to change: A story of hope in Uttarakhand's remote Villages

As government initiatives push forward rural road development, the hope remains that these villages will soon find themselves linked to a future of greater possibilities

In the mountains, roads are more than just paths from one place to another—they are lifelines. They connect people to schools, hospitals, and markets, making daily life easier and opportunities more accessible. For many **remote** villages in Uttarakhand, however, the **wait** for a proper road **continues**, shaping everyday realities in ways that outsiders rarely see.

In Surag and Bhagdhanu villages of Garud Block, Bageshwar District, the **absence** of a proper road **is** a challenge that residents **navigate** every day. The people here have **adapted**—carrying **essentials** on foot, finding their ways to reach schools and markets, and supporting each other through difficult times.

Yet, **the dream** of a well-built road **remains**. Kedar Singh, 70, has spent a lifetime in Surag. He describes how **unpaved**, **uneven** roads make even the simplest tasks difficult, especially during the monsoon. “When it rains, the paths become slippery, making it hard for both people and animals to move. We take our cattle to **graze** on the mountains, but during the rains, they **often** slip on the muddy paths and fall down the slopes. It’s **heartbreaking** to see, and it makes our work much harder.” For many, the challenge is not just about movement but about access to essential services. Nandi Devi, 45, explains how women and elderly residents face particular difficulties: “When someone falls ill, finding transport is nearly impossible. Vehicles don’t come here because of the poor road conditions. We have to **rely on** each other and make do with what we have.”

For students, an incomplete road is more than an **inconvenience**—it shapes their future. Bhavana Rawal, a 10th-grade student, walks 5 km every day on an unpaved road to reach her school in Sailani, 9 km away. “Most of the time, we manage, but during the rains, we arrive at school covered in mud. On some days, we can’t go at all,” she says. Kavita, 18, has similar concerns. “During the monsoon and winter, getting to school is **incredibly** difficult. The steep paths become dangerous, and there is always the fear of slipping. Sometimes, we miss school for days, which affects our studies.”

Efforts have been made over the years to bring road connectivity to Surag and Bhagdhanu. A **survey** for the road’s construction **was** conducted, and discussions continued resolving land-related concerns. **Local leaders**, like village head Champa Devi, **have** been **advocating** for progress, and there is **optimism** that change will come.

In Uttarakhand, over 33,500 km of roads have already been built, with 171 km of new roads planned for 2024-25 under the Pradhan Mantri Gram Sadak Yojana. Across the state, better road connectivity has opened doors to education, healthcare, and employment. There is hope that **the Rs 70,000 crore**

allocated in the Union Budget for rural roads **will** also reach villages like Surag and Bhagdhanu, ensuring that they, too, become part of this expanding network.

For now, the people of these villages continue their journeys—on foot, through difficult terrain, with patience and **resilience**. But with **consistent** efforts from local communities, government agencies, and **policymakers**, the day is not far when these paths will finally be paved, bringing with them new possibilities for those who have waited the longest.

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.

[\[Practice Exercise\]](#)

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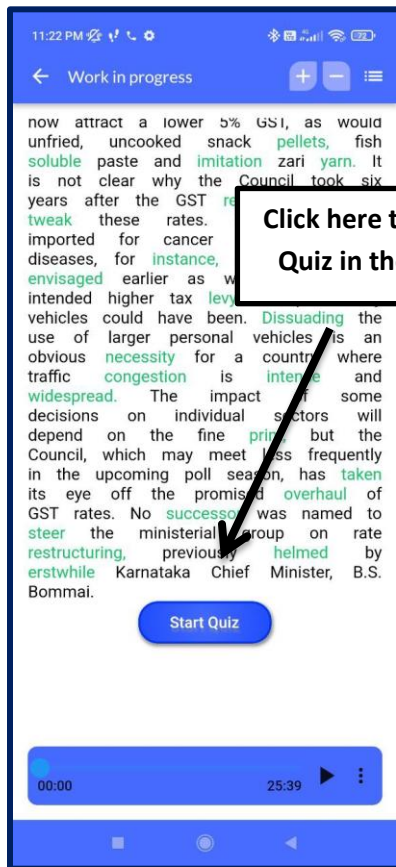
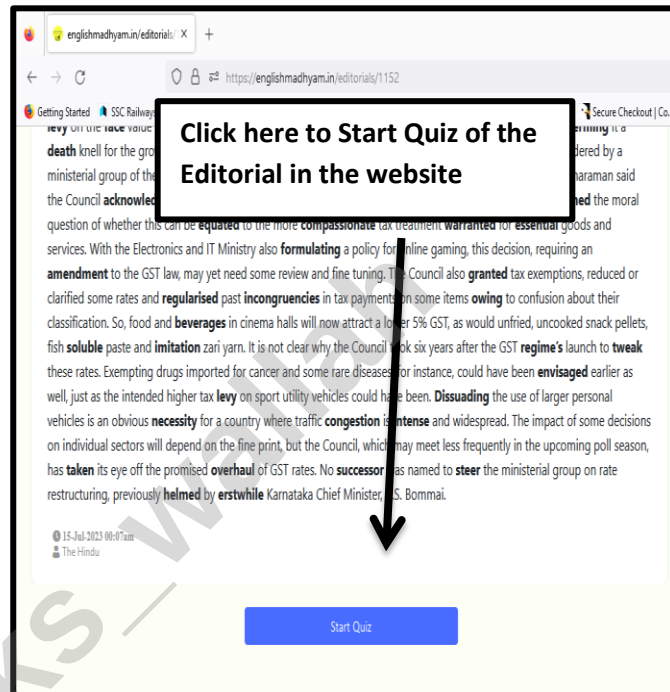
Vocabulary

1. **Remote** (adjective) – Distant, Isolated, Far-off, Secluded, Inaccessible दूरस्थ
2. **Navigate** (verb) – Traverse, Travel, Cross, Maneuver, Steer मार्ग तय करना
3. **Adapt** (verb) – Adjust, Acclimate, Modify, Alter, Familiarize अनुकूलित करना
4. **Essential** (noun) – Necessity, Requirement, Basic, Fundamental, Vital आवश्यकता
5. **Unpaved** (adjective) – Rough, Dirt, Gravel, Unsurfaced, Unsealed बिना पक्की सड़क वाला
6. **Uneven** (adjective) – Rough, Bumpy, Irregular, Rugged, Jagged असमान
7. **Graze** (verb) – Feed, Browse, Pasture, Forage, Nibble चरना
8. **Often** (adverb) – Frequently, Regularly, Repeatedly, Commonly, Habitually अक्सर
9. **Heartbreaking** (adjective) – Sad, Tragic, Painful, Distressing, Devastating दिल तोड़ने वाला
10. **Rely** (on) (verb) – Depend, Trust, Count, Bank, Lean निर्भर होना
11. **Inconvenience** (noun) – Difficulty, Trouble, Hassle, Discomfort, Bother असुविधा
12. **Incredibly** (adverb) – Extremely, Remarkably, Unbelievably, Exceptionally, Astonishingly अविश्वसनीय रूप से
13. **Advocate** (verb) – Support, Promote, Champion, Endorse, Back समर्थन करना
14. **Optimism** (noun) – Hope, Positivity, Confidence, Cheerfulness, Expectation आशावाद
15. **Resilience** (noun) – Toughness, Endurance, Flexibility, Strength, Adaptability मज़बूती
16. **Consistent** (adjective) – Steady, Regular, Constant, Persistent, Reliable सुसंगत
17. **Policymaker** (noun) – Decision-maker, Legislator, Administrator, Regulator, Official नीति निर्माता

Summary of the Editorial

1. Roads in mountainous regions act as lifelines, crucial for connecting people to essential services.
2. Several remote villages in Uttarakhand still lack proper roads, remaining isolated from broader development.
3. Surag and Bhagdhanu villages in Garud Block, Bageshwar District, illustrate the daily struggles caused by poor road connectivity.
4. Residents rely on foot to transport essentials, highlighting their resilience and adaptability.
5. Monsoons make unpaved paths especially treacherous, increasing accidents for both people and livestock.
6. In times of illness, the lack of vehicle accessibility makes reaching healthcare extremely difficult.
7. Women and elderly residents face additional hardships due to steep, slippery terrain.
8. Students, such as Bhavana and Kavita, must walk long distances to attend school, with rains and winters disrupting their education.
9. Land surveys have been conducted to build a proper road, and local leaders continue to advocate for urgent action.
10. Over 33,500 km of rural roads have been built in Uttarakhand, reflecting ongoing development efforts.
11. The Pradhan Mantri Gram Sadak Yojana plans an additional 171 km of roads for 2024-25 in the state.
12. The Union Budget's allocation of Rs 70,000 crore for rural roads fuels hope for improved connectivity in remote areas.
13. Better roads in other parts of Uttarakhand have significantly boosted education, healthcare, and employment opportunities.
14. Community cooperation and consistent lobbying by local authorities are key to accelerating road projects in Surag and Bhagdhanu.
15. Despite current challenges, persistent government initiatives and public support suggest that these villages may soon be connected to wider possibilities and growth.

Practice Exercise: SSC Pattern Based

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